IT may seem odd to be talking of happiness when the world has barely emerged from the immense grief two-plus years of the Covid pandemic inflicted on us. Or seen much strife, including the debilitating war in Ukraine that, if allowed to fester, could end up as the war of the worlds. Or to usher a new year with joy when there are dire predictions of a global recession that could lead to massive job cuts, high inflation and heightened misery.

Yet it is precisely why we should be searching for answers to the secrets of happiness. For, as Mahatma Gandhi put it, "Strength does not come from winning. When you go through hardships and decide not to surrender, that is strength." So it is with the quest for happiness—how do you rise even as you keep falling and live anew? The first of the four noble truths enunciated by the Buddha was accepting that the world was full of suffering. The remaining three go into the causes and the paths to attain *moksha*, the ultimate liberation from the seemingly endless cycle of birth and death. The question of how best to do that then itself becomes the quest.

Since 2012, the UN has engaged an independent agency to bring out a World Happiness Report and rank the happiest countries. To assess a nation's state of happiness, the global survey relies on three key markers of well-being: the person's current life evaluation, positive emotions and negative effects. Interestingly, the study found that positive emotions like laughter, enjoyment or learning something new figure twice more frequently in the answers than negative feelings like worry, sadness and anger. The world, it seems, is learning to cope far better than before.

THE PATH TO BLISS, AS WISE MEN HAVE SAID, CAN BE FOUND IN THE ART OF NOT JUST LIVING, BUT ALSO OF GIVING

India, however, inexplicably finds itself among the countries at the bottom of the list in the current edition of the World Happiness Report, figuring below even Pakistan, Sri Lanka and Nepal. Finland tops the ranking, followed by many other Scandinavian countries, with the combination of material wellbeing, social cohesion and sense of ownership in government policy giving them a decisive advantage. India, though, can take heart from the fact that its citizens do not necessarily have to be bound by such narrow definitions of what constitutes contentment. For, the same study has found that in the past decade, the word "happiness" has occurred more frequently than the phrases "gross domestic product" (GDP), "livelihood and income", the older markers of progress, both of which have seen a declining frequency in usage.

So here we are at the crossroads of a new year, looking at how to navigate the twists and turns that life throws at us and deal with them with an equanimity that redefines the notion of happiness. Not as a national quest to improve the GDP or any personal search for material and physiological comfort but as the many gurus that have contributed to this special issue on happiness have talked about—the art of not just living but giving and in that sharing finding the elusive state of bliss. You will also find in the issue heartwarming stories of exemplars who have forgone their own comforts and found joy in making others feel happy. There are prominent individuals who by their diverse definitions of happiness have given us pause to think on how we look at the ultimate truth of our existence and the paths we can take to achieve or experience it. So, enjoy the read and the ride. ■